From Mother . . . With Love

By Ellen Gilchrist

INTRODUCTION

Letting go of a child is hard for every mother to deal with. Yet perhaps, it is even harder for a child to let go of her mother. Minta Hawley grapples with her mother's eminent death in "From Mother...With Love" bu Zoa Sherburne.

The day that Minta Hawley grew up was a crisp golden day in early September.

It began like any other Saturday, with Minta lying in bed an extra hour. Breakfast was always lazy and unhurried on Saturday mornings. The three of them in the breakfast room. Mom, Dad and Minta.They talked, the casual happy talk of people who love each other and don't have to make conversation. About neighborhood doings . . . about items in the paper . . . about the clothes Minta would need when she went away to school in a couple of weeks.

It was after the dishes were finished that

4NG Fanatics

Minta's father asked her if she would like to go down to the beach for a little while. "Low tide," he said. "Might get a few clams."

He was silent as they drove toward the beach, but it wasn't the companionable silence that Minta had come to expect from him. There was something grim about it. "He's going to talk to me about school," Minta told herself. "He's going to try to talk me out of it again."

Last year was different. With mother just recovering from that operation it was natural that he should expect Minta to stay home; she had even wanted to stay. But now going to MaryHill was something special. She would live in a dormitory and be part of all the campus fun. It wasn't as if MaryHill were clear across the country, either, she'd probably be getting home every month or so . . . and there were the Christmas holidays . . . and then spring vacation.

Minta's chin was lifted in a stubborn line as her father parked the car and went around to get the shovels and pail form the trunk. It wasn't like him to be

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so stubborn; usually he was jolly and easy going and inclined to leave such matters entirely up to Minta's mother.

She followed him down to the beach, her boots squishing in the wet sand. The tide was far out and farther up the beach she could see bent figures busily digging along the water's edge. A scattered beach fire smoldered near the bank and Minta poked it into place and revived it with splinters of driftwood until she had coaxed back a steady warning blaze. When she sat back on her heels to smile up at her father she felt her throat constrict with a smothering fear. His eyes looked the way they had when. . .When?

Suddenly she remembered. He was looking at her and trying to smile, just the way he had looked at her the time her appendix burst and they were taking her to the hospital. She could almost hear the wail of the ambulance siren and feel the way he had held her hands tightly, trying to make it easier. His eyes had told her then, as they told her now, that he would a thousand times rather bear the pain than watch her suffer.

4NG Fanatics

He took her hand and pulled her to her feet and they started walking up the beach slowly, not toward the group of people digging clams, but in the other direction, toward the jagged pile of rocks that jutted out into the bay.

"I went to see Dr. Morton last week, Minta. I've been seeing him pretty regularly these last few months."

She flashed a quick frightened look up at him. "You aren't ill?"

"No." He sighed and it was a heartbreaking sound. "No. It isn't me. It's your mother. That's why I don't want you to go to MaryHill this year."

"But . . . but she's feeling so much better, Dad. even taking on a little weight–" She broke off and stopped walking and her hand was steady on his arm. "Tell me," she said quietly.

Her mother was going to die To die. Her mother. To die, the doctor said. Three months, perhaps less. . . . Her mother who was gay and scatterbrained and more fun than anyone else in the world. Her mother who could be counted on

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to announce in the spring that she was going to do her Christmas shopping early this year, and then left everything until the week before Christmas. No one was worse about forgetting anniversaries and birthdays and things like that; but the easy-to-remember dates, like Valentine's Day and St. Patrick's Day and Halloween were always gala affairs complete with table favors and three-decker cakes.

Minta's mother wore the highest heels of any mother on the block. She was so pretty. And she always had time for things like listening to new records and helping paste pictures in Minta's scrapbook. She wasn't ever sick—

"I shouldn't have told you." Her father was speaking in a voice that Minta had never heard from him before. A voice that held loneliness and fear and a sort of angry pain. "I was afraid I couldn't make you understand, why you had to stay home . . . why you'd have to forget about MaryHill for this year." His eyes begged her to forgive him and for some reason she wanted to put her arms around him, as if she were much

4NG Fanatics

older and stronger.

"Of course you had to tell me," she said steadily. "Of course I had to know." And then—"Three months but Dad, that's Christmas."

He talked quietly, explaining, telling her everything the doctor had said, and Minta listened without tears, without tears, without comment. She watched his face as though it were the face of a stranger. She thought about a thousand unrelated things.

It was like coming back from a long journey when her father stopped talking and they turned back toward the car. "So that's why I can't let you go away, Midge." Her father's voice was very low and he didn't seem to realize that he had called her by the babyish name she had discarded when she started to first grade. "It isn't just your mother I'm thinking about . . . it's me. I need you."

She looked at him quickly and her heart twisted with pity. He did need her. He would need her more than ever.

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"We can't tell her, Minta. The doctor left it up to me and I said not to tell her. We have to let her have this last time . . . this last little time . . . without that hanging over her. We have to go on as if everything were exactly the same."

She nodded to show that she understood. After a moment she spoke past the ache in her throat. "About school. I'll . . . I'll tell her that I decided to wait until next year. Or that I'm afraid I'd be lonesome without the gang. I've been sort of . . . sort of seesawing back and forth, anyway."

It seemed impossible that life could go on exactly as before. The small private world peopled by the three of them was as snug and warm and happy as though no shadow had touched them.

They watched television and argued good-naturedly about the programs. Minta's friends came and went and there was the usual round of parties and dances and games. Her father continued to bowl two evenings a week and her mother became involved in various preholiday pursuits.

4N6 Fanatics

"I really must get at my Christmas shopping," she mentioned the day she was wrapping trick-or-treat candy for Halloween. Minta shook her head and sighed gustily.

It was amazing that Minta could laugh and say, "Oh, you . . ." the way she did year after year.

It was a knife turning in her heart when her mother straightened up from the gay cellophane-wrapped candies and brushed a stray wisp of taffy-colored hair back from one flushed cheek.

"Don't laugh," she said, pretending to be stern. "You know you're just exactly like me."

She wanted to put her arm around her mother and hug her, hard. She wanted to say, "I hope I am like you. I want to be." But instead she got up and stretched and wrinkled her nose. "Perish forbid," she said, "that I should be such a scatterbrain." She was rewarded by the flash of a dimple in her mother's cheek.

It seemed to Minta, as week followed week, that the day at the beach had been something out of a nightmare: Something that she could push away from

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her and forget about. Sometimes she looked at her father, laughing, teasing them, or howling about the month-end bills and she thought, "It didn't happen . . . it isn't
true."

And in the dark hours of the night Minta had known it wasn't a nightmare. It was true. It was true.

One windy November day she hurried home from school and found her mother in the yard raking leaves. Minta stopped and leaned on the gate. She saw with a new awareness that there were dark circles under her mother's eyes and that the flags of color in her cheeks were too bright. But she managed a chuckle.

"I wish you could see yourself, Mom. I'll get my camera and take a picture of you." She ran into the house and got her camera and they took a whole roll of pictures.

"Good," her mother said complacently. "Now we can show them to your father the next time he accuses me of being a Sally-Sit-by-the-Fire." Her mother was tired that night. She lay on the davenport and made

4N6 Fanatics

out her Christmas card list while Minta and her father watched the wrestling matches. It was like a thousand other such evenings but in some unaccountable way it was different.

"Because it's the last time," Minta told herself. "The last time we'll ever rake the leaves and make a bonfire in the alley. The last time I'll snap a picture of her with her arms around the Kelly kids. The last time . . . the last time. . . . "

That night she wakened in the chilly darkness of her room and began to cry, softly, her head buried in the curve of her arm. At first it helped, loosening the tight bands about her heart, washing away the fear and the loneliness, but when she tried to stop she found that she couldn't. Great wracking sobs shook her
until she could no longer smother them against her pillow. And then the light was on and her mother was there bending over her, her face concerned, her voice soothing.

"Darling, what is it? Wake up, baby, you're having a bad dream."

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"No . . . no, it isn't a dream," Minta choked. "It's true . . . it's true."

The thin hand kept smoothing back her tumbled hair and her mother went on talking in the tone she had always used to comfort a much smaller Minta. "Want me to leave the light on in case your spook comes back?"

Minta shook her head, blinking against the tears that crowded against her eyelids, even managing a wobbly smile. She never cried again.

Not even when the ambulance came a week later to take her mother to the hospital. Not even when she was standing beside her mother's high white hospital bed, holding her hand tightly, Not even at the funeral. . .

.

One night he came to the door of her room where she was studying. "I wonder if you'd like to go through those clothes before your Aunt Grace takes them to the church bazaar," he began haltingly.

And then when she looked up at him, not understanding, he went on gently, "Your mother's clothes. We thought someone might as well get some

4NG Fanatics

good out of them."

She stood up and closed the book and went past him without another word, but she closed the door behind her when she went into her mother's room. Her hands felt slightly unsteady as she pulled open the closet door. A faint perfume clung to most of her garments. Minta started folding the things with haste, stuffing them into boxes, cramming the lids on and then starting on another box.

At the very back of the closet were the two pieces of matched luggage that had been her mother's last birthday gift from her father. They were heavy when she tried to move them—too heavy.

She brought them out into the room and put them side by side on her mother's bed. Her breath caught in her throat when she opened them.

Dozens and dozens of boxes, all tied with bright red ribbon, the gift tags written out in her mother's careful script. Gaily colored Christmas stickers, sprigs of holly. To Minta from Mother and Dad . . . to Grace from Mary . . . to John from Mary . . . to the Kelly

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4NG Fanatics

Gremlins from Aunt Mary . . . to Uncle Art from the Hawley family. . . .

"So you knew," Minta whispered the words. "You knew all the time."

She looked down in surprise as a hot tear dropped on her hand and she dashed it away almost impatiently. She picked up another package and read the tag. To Minta from Mother . . . with love.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Zoa Sherburne
Book: Early September
ISBN: 978-0176014278
Publisher: Nelson Canada
Date (Month/Year): 1980

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier

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